

Chicken Curry

Yogurt-based · garlic-forward · no tomato · stovetop

YIELD	ACTIVE	ONION RATIO	FAT RATIO
6–8	~1.25 hr	1:1 to protein	10% of protein

KEY TARGETS

visual states — the bhuna is judged by eye, not clock

Onion paste	Deep brown, jammy — ~75% volume loss, smell sweet not sharp.
Bhuna (masala)	Oil separates — paste goes curdled & matte, clear oil pools in "craters" and at the edges.
Yogurt	Oil separates again after each addition before the next.
Sauce	Clings to the meat, coats a spoon.
Garlic finish	Hits the nose immediately on serving.
Final	Thick, glossy, not watery.

INGREDIENTS

1.5 kg chicken batch

Chicken boneless thigh, chunked	1.5 kg	Garlic minced, for finish	30 g
Onion sliced thin	1.5 kg	Salt ~12g at sear, rest to taste	18 g
Ghee (100 + 30 + 20)	150 g	Lemon juice	15 g
Yogurt full-fat, room temp	225 g	Kasuri methi crushed	2–3 g
Ginger-garlic paste DIY, below	60 g	Green chilies slit	2–3

SPICES

whole = bloom (step 4) · ground = fry in fat (step 5)

WHOLE — BLOOM, STEP 4

Cumin seed	6 g
Green cardamom	4 pods
Black cardamom	2 pods
Cinnamon	1 stick
Bay	3 leaves
Cloves	4

GROUND — FRY IN FAT, STEP 5

Kashmiri chili color, mild	30 g
Hot chili	7 g
Turmeric	4 g

GARAM MASALA — USED IN TWO STAGES

Bloom half with ground spices, step 5	3.5 g
Finish half off heat, step 11	3.5 g

DIY ginger-garlic paste: 60g garlic + 60g ginger (1:1), peeled. Blend with **15–30 ml water** — minimum to form a smooth paste. Yield **~120g**; use 60g here. Keeps **5–7 days** fridge, **3 months** frozen. Turns bitter after 24 hr at room temp — fresh is brighter.

Build the Curry

METHOD

stovetop — oil separation gates every stage

- 1 **Onions:** 100g ghee, add onions. **50–60 min medium**, stir every 5–7 min. Done: volume down ~75%, no steam releasing, smell sweet not sharp, color deep brown & jammy.
- 2 **Blend:** tilt the pot, immersion-blend the onions to a smooth paste in the residual fat — no water. (Traditional blender: remove center cap, cover with towel, vent steam.)
- 3 **Fry the paste (bhuna):** 30g ghee, return paste, **8–10 min medium**, stir constantly. Done: paste looks **curdled and matte**, clear oil pools in "craters" and at the edges. Non-negotiable — rushing = raw taste.
- 4 **Bloom:** push paste to the sides, add whole spices to the fat in the center, **30–45 sec** until fragrant and sizzling, stir in. Add 60g ginger-garlic paste, **2–3 min** until the raw smell is gone.
- 5 **Ground spices:** medium-low. Add the ground spices + the **first 3.5g garam masala (bloom half)**. Fry **45–60 sec** in the fat. Splash **50 ml water**, cook until oil separates.
- 6 **Yogurt:** low heat. Temper first — whisk **~5g hot paste** into the yogurt bowl (prevents curdling). Add **~30g at a time**, waiting for oil to separate before each. **10–12 min** total.
- 7 **Sear:** high heat. Add chicken, season with **~12g salt** (hold the rest). Sear **4–5 min** until opaque — building fond.
- 8 **Simmer:** add **~300 ml hot water**, scrape up the fond, cover and simmer until the chicken is cooked through — **~15–20 min** for thigh chunks. Stir once or twice.
- 9 **Reduce:** uncover, medium-high. Reduce until the sauce clings to the chicken, **8–12 min**. Now taste and bring to **final salt** (the held ~6g, to taste) — after reduction, not before.
- 10 **Garlic finish:** small pan, 20g ghee + 30g minced garlic + slit chilies. **60–90 sec** to just-golden edges (not brown). Pour into the curry.
- 11 **Finish:** off heat. Add the **second 3.5g garam masala (finish half)**, kasuri methi, 15g lemon. The garlic should hit your nose immediately.

The bhuna — oil separation is the whole game: it happens at steps 3, 5, and 6. The paste goes wet/glossy → matte/curdled → oil pools in craters. The oil should be **tinted red/yellow** — clear oil means the spices haven't released. Rush this and the curry is raw and flat.

Read & Adjust

TROUBLESHOOTING

PROBLEM	CAUSE	FIX
Watery / thin sauce	Under-reduced onions; bhuna rushed	Reduce longer at step 9; oil must separate at steps 3, 5, 6
Tastes raw / flat	Bhuna rushed; bloom skipped	No shortcuts on oil separation; bloom the spices in fat
No garlic punch	Finish garlic overcooked	Golden edges only, not brown; add right before serving
Too hot / dry	Chili concentrated; not enough fat	Add 20–30g ghee — NOT water. Fat mellows heat.
Yogurt curdled	Cold yogurt; heat too high	Room temp; temper first; keep heat low

NOTES & SCALING

Onion ratio: 1:1 minimum. If the sauce runs thin, go 1.25:1.

Fat: 10% is conservative — restaurants run 12–15%. Dry or too spicy? Add ghee, never water.

Yogurt: room temp, temper first, low heat — the three guards against curdling.

Whole spices: bloom in fat — extracts more than dry heat alone.

Make ahead: better the next day. Add fresh-fried garlic when reheating to bring the punch back.

Scaling: doubles linearly — but the onion fry stretches to **70–80 min** at 2×.

Why no tomato: the body comes from the deeply browned onion paste and the yogurt, not acid + sugar from tomato. It's a richer, rounder base — the garlic finish and kasuri methi carry the top notes.